standards were fixed depending upon the year of inception of the plant and other factors. Unfortunately, the ministry had no idea whether appropriate technology exists and how costly it would be if imported. There was also no consideration of how the additional cost would get factored in. In such situations, dictates often remain unimplemented. This is what happened in case of NOx and SOx. The deadline has come and gone but compliance is hardly 5–10 per cent.

Environmental courts like the National Green Tribunal have also adopted the dictate methodology. Every now and then, orders are passed to stop production or take a particular step with a threatened penalty of jail. A case in point is the burning of stubble by farmers in Punjab and Haryana. There are several solutions to the problem but instead of coming up with an appropriate one, including the use of public funds for a cause like this, only farmers are being targeted. Despite the spectre of criminal punishment, farmers are not heeding these dictates as the economic logic of preparing the field for sowing wheat in the quickest turnaround time prevails.

There have been efforts of late to de-clog the system and expedite environmental clearances. The Environment Impact Assessment Draft Rules, 2020, are a small step in this direction. Unfortunately, people who are overly concerned with non-environmental issues—mostly of a social nature—and who have used parts of the process like consultation to put a spoke in the wheel of industrialization, urbanization and infrastructure creation are objecting to these reforms. These reforms should be expedited, though they would have only a limited effect.

The real solution lies in the ministry focusing on a significant reduction of carbon and pollution emissions without adversely affecting economic growth and employment.